



1. Mount Fuji, a stratovolcano on the island of Honshū, visible from Tokyo
2. Shinobazu-no-ike Benten-dō, a Buddhist temple of goddess Benzaiten, on an island in the middle of Shinobazu Pond, located in Taitō, Tokyo, Japan

3. A classic shrimp bento. A Japanese iteration of a single-portion boxed meal, bento is considered a form of communication between the maker and the eater
4. Faiz Shakir at Lands End in San Francisco

41-year-old Shakir witnessed firsthand how every interaction was an opportunity to express sincere respect. “Every gesture, from precise bows to meticulous service, painted a portrait of treating guests like deities—more than just words, it’s a living principle. Beneath the surface, this insight holds universal wisdom. Tokyo taught me that genuine respect is an art—a powerful, transformative force that enriches both the giver and the recipient.”

Beyond the landmarks, landscapes and culture, his travels have enabled him to delve into the heart of a place through its food. No wonder, culinary exploration has become an integral part of his

itinerary. “Each trip is an invitation to savour new flavours. The act of breaking bread with locals, conversing over shared meals, and exploring the intricacies of regional flavours has created memories that transcend time and space.” For instance, during his recent trips to Delhi, he found himself indulging in *rajma-chawal* more than he would like to admit, and in Goa, it was a seafood feast all the way.

For Shakir, travelling holds a basket of perks. Through his many journeys, he has discovered that travelling to distant places brings him closer to his core. The act of wandering has filled his soul with inspiration drawn from diverse

cultures and landscapes, and he has often returned from these trips with renewed vigour. “As I roam through unfamiliar streets and embrace novel experiences, my mind finds solace in the simplicity of the present, untethered from the complexities of daily life. The memories etched in the landscapes I’ve traversed serve as a reminder that each journey is not only an exploration of the external world but also a profound journey within myself.”

As Shakir says, balancing the thrill of discovery with cherished moments is, for him, the key to a well-rounded life. **BT**

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